headed by a national security adviser (NSA). Vajpayee appointed his trusted adviser, former diplomat Brajesh Mishra, as India's first national security adviser. Mishra was also principal secretary to the prime minister. This dual position combined with Vajpayee's total trust in him meant that after Rajiv this was the first time the prime minister's office fully ran foreign and domestic policy. According to former officials, the depth of the intrusion was demonstrated even with respect to administrative issues like appointment of ambassadors.

Two incidents during the Vajpayee government illustrate the prime minister's role as the key decision maker, with only a secondary role for his cabinet. The first of these occurred when in May 1999, while India was engaged in peace talks with Pakistan, its military was caught off-guard by Pakistani troops that captured mountainous territory across the line of control in Kashmir in the Kargil region. This marked the beginning of the Kargil crisis, which is said to have brought India and Pakistan to the brink of a nuclear exchange. The Indian Army eventually beat back the Pakistani intruders and international public opinion was unanimously on India's side. Even China joined the United States and other countries in demanding Pakistan's withdrawal from territory it had surreptitiously captured.

Several official reports have detailed India's intelligence failure (both human and technical) that led to the Kargil crisis. Once the crisis had presented itself, the prime minister made the major decisions about militarily confronting the intruders as well as to mobilize world opinion against Pakistan's stab in the back. However, Vajpayee was mindful of likely criticism at being caught napping and over-trusting Pakistan without putting in place mechanisms for verifying its trustworthiness. He, therefore, ensured that the Cabinet Committee on Security met daily, often a couple of times every day, during the course of the crisis. These meetings were attended by all service chiefs and intelligence heads so that no one could absolve himself of responsibility for decisions taken during the period.